

Distinct pathways to possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction in Mesoamerican languages*

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1. Introduction

The Mesoamerican linguistic area consists of several distinct language families, which share a number of structural features (Campbell et al. 1986). In this short paper, we focus on the following: (i) verb-initiality (either VOS or VSO), (ii) the possibility of “Pied-Piping With Inversion”¹ (henceforth, PPWI) of wh-possessors in complex possessive phrases (Smith Stark 1988, Aissen 1996), and—as a counterpart to (ii)—(iii) the appearance of bare $\bar{A}$ -extraction of wh-possessors out of such phrases.

We investigate the nature of possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction in the Tzeltalan languages (Mayan) (based on Aissen and Polian 2025) and in San Martín Peras Mixtec (Otomanguean) (based on the first author’s fieldwork).² Although Tzeltalan and San Martín Peras Mixtec (henceforth, SMPM) are unrelated, their possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction profiles look superficially similar. As shown in (1)–(2), in both language types, wh-possessors may be fronted clause-initially, either with the rest of the complex possessive phrase (PPWI), (a), or alone, (b). Note that the translations reveal interpretive differences between the (a) and (b) examples, to be discussed in Section 3.³

- (1) a. [**Mach’a x-nich’an** ___] bejk’aj ___ ?
 who A3-child.of-male COMPL.be.born
 ‘Whose child was born?’

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¹Also known as “Secondary Wh-movement” (Heck 2008).

²Abbreviations: A = set A agreement (=ERG), AML = animal, APPL = applicative, B = set B agreement (=ABS), CLF = classifier, COMPL = completive aspect, CONT = continuative aspect, DET = determiner, ENC = enclitic, FAM = familiar, ICP = incompletive aspect, INTR = intransitive, P = preposition, PL = plural, POSS = possessive, POT = potential aspect, SG = singular, 2 = 2nd person, 3 = 3rd person.

³For reasons of space, our paper focuses just on the (b) constructions; PPWI is presented solely for comparison. See Hedding and Yuan to appear for details about PPWI.

- b. **Mach’a** bejk’aj [**x-nich’an** ___]?
 who COMPL.be.born A3-child.of-male
 ‘Who had a child born?’ (Oxchuc Tseltal; Polian 2013)
- (2) a. [**Yóó se’ě** ___] kàku ___ ?
 who child be.born.COMPL
 ‘Whose child was born?’
- b. **Yóó nà** kàku [**se’ě** ___]?
 who 3PL born.COMPL child
 ‘Who (pl.) had a child born?’ / ‘Whose (pl.) child was born?’ (SMPM)

The central finding of this paper is that, despite their surface-similar empirical profiles, possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction in Tseltalan and SMPM actually involves *underlyingly divergent derivational pathways*. Following Aissen and Polian 2025, putative ‘ $\bar{A}$ -subextraction’ in Tseltalan in (1b) is actually $\bar{A}$ -extraction of a *raised possessor* outside of the complex possessive phrase; there is no $\bar{A}$ -subextraction directly out of possessive phrases in Tseltalan. In contrast, we argue that SMPM does permit genuine $\bar{A}$ -extraction of possessors out of complex DPs (though we also show that its occurrence is systematically restricted to certain positions).

To account for this contrast, we suggest that these distinct profiles arise from a number of (micro-)parametric differences conspiring in the respective languages. These differences pertain to the possible sizes of the possessive phrases (e.g., DP or smaller), the functional heads involved in both V(P)-movement and A-movement in deriving verb-initial word order (T vs. *v*), and whether *v*, a phase head, may Agree with and thus ‘unlock’ lower DP phases, building on the theory of phasal subextraction of Rackowski and Richards 2005.

Importantly, although this paper focuses on just two grammatical patterns (from two different language families), these differences offer predictions for the behavior of possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction in other Mesoamerican languages, which we hope can be tested in future research.

2. Overview of Tseltalan and SMPM syntax

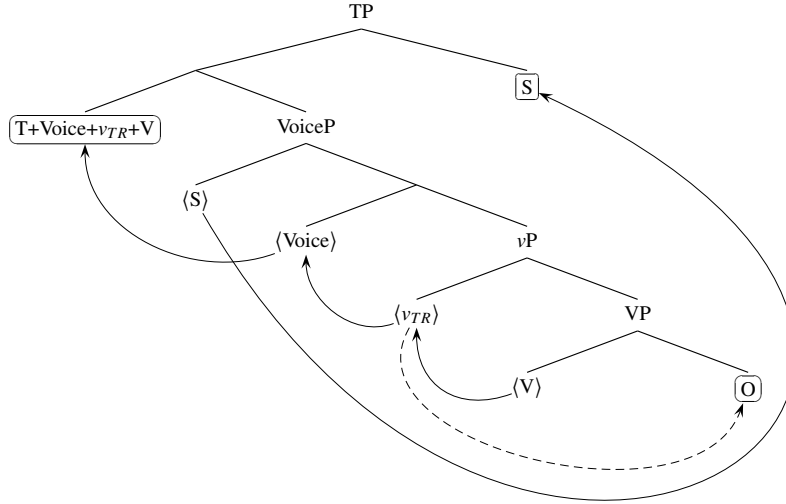
The Mesoamerican linguistic area spans southern Mexico and much of Central America, and includes several language families and language isolates. In this paper, we compare Mayan languages of the Tseltalan subbranch (e.g., Tseltal, Tsotsil) using data from Aissen and Polian 2025, and an Otomanguean language, San Martín Peras Mixtec (original fieldwork, building on Hedding 2022 and Hedding and Yuan to appear).

The Tseltalan languages are V(erb)-O(bject)-S(ubject), analyzed by Aissen and Polian (2025) as involving head movement of the verb to T and movement of the subject to a right-pointing specifier.⁴ The Tseltalan languages are “low-absolutive” Mayan languages, meaning that the object does not raise past the subject (i.e., it remains *in-situ*). Following Coon et al. 2014 and Coon et al. 2021, we assume that absolutive case is assigned by *v*

⁴See also Clemens and Coon 2018 and Little 2020 on right specifiers in Mayan more generally.

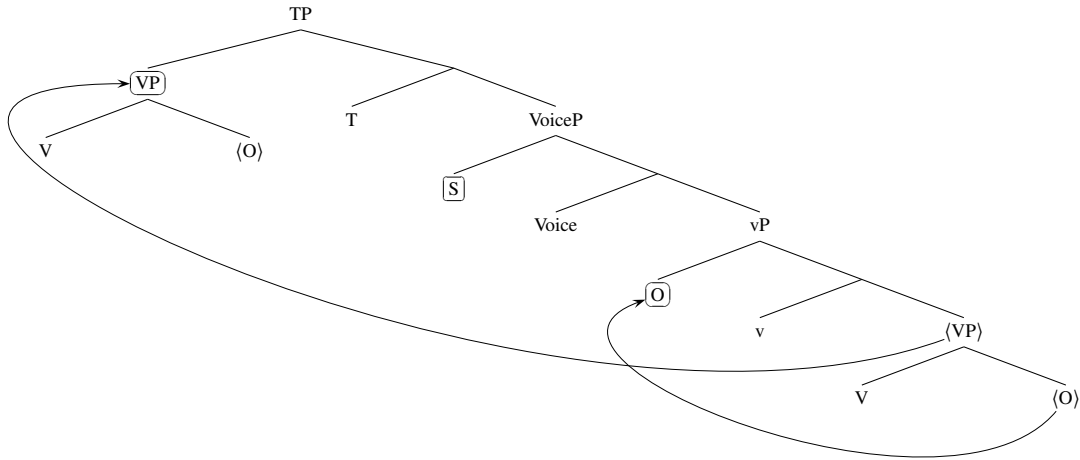
to the highest internal argument, indicated with a dashed line in the following tree. The morphological result of this Agree relation is “set B” agreement on the verb.

(3)



SMPM is a V(erb)-S(ubject)-O(bject) language and only has left-oriented specifiers. Following Hedding and Yuan to appear and Yuan and Juárez Chávez 2024, we assume that this basic word order is derived via object shift of all internal arguments to spec-*v*P, followed by remnant VP movement to spec-TP. The subject is not overtly moved, remaining in its base-generated position (which we assume to be spec-VoiceP). Unlike Tseltalan, SMPM does not have any overt case morphology, so throughout this paper we use object shift as a diagnostic for Agree with *v*.

(4)



3. Possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction in Tseltalan and SMPM

Aissen and Polian 2025 propose that there is no true $\bar{A}$ -subextraction in Tseltalan. Rather, stranding of a possessum requires a step of A-movement by the *wh*-possessor. In this

section, we enumerate 6 differences between Tseltalan and SMPM which suggest that Aissen and Polian’s (2025) analysis should not be extended to SMPM.

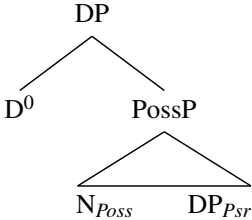
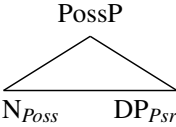
3.1 Specificity and nominal size

3.1.1 Tseltalan

Aissen and Polian show (following Polian 2013) that there is an interpretive difference between PPWI, (5a), and possessor subextraction, (5b).⁵ The difference in the constructions correlates with the specificity of the the possessum: (5a) presupposes the existence of a specific child, while (5b) does not.

- (5) a. [_{DP} Mach’a x-nich’an] bejk’aj?
 who A3-child.of.male COMPL.be.born
 ‘Whose child was born?’
 b. [_{DP} Mach’a] bejk’aj [_{PossP} x-nich’an ___]?
 who COMPL.be.born A3-child.of.male
 ‘Who had a child born?’ (Oxchuc Tseltal; Polian 2013)

Aissen and Polian propose that specific nominals are DPs, (6a), while non-specific nominals are structurally reduced (following e.g., Pereltsvaig 2006), projecting only as far as PossP, (6b). This structural difference impacts whether they may undergo A-movement. When an A-probe on T searches its domain, it will find and move the most local DP. If the possessum is specific, the most local DP will correspond to the entire possessive phrase. If non-specific (and structurally reduced), the most local DP will be the possessor alone.

- (6) a. Specific Possessive
- 
- DP
 / \
D⁰ PossP
 / \
N_{Poss} DP_{Psr}
- b. Non-specific Possessive
- 
- PossP
 / \
N_{Poss} DP_{Psr}

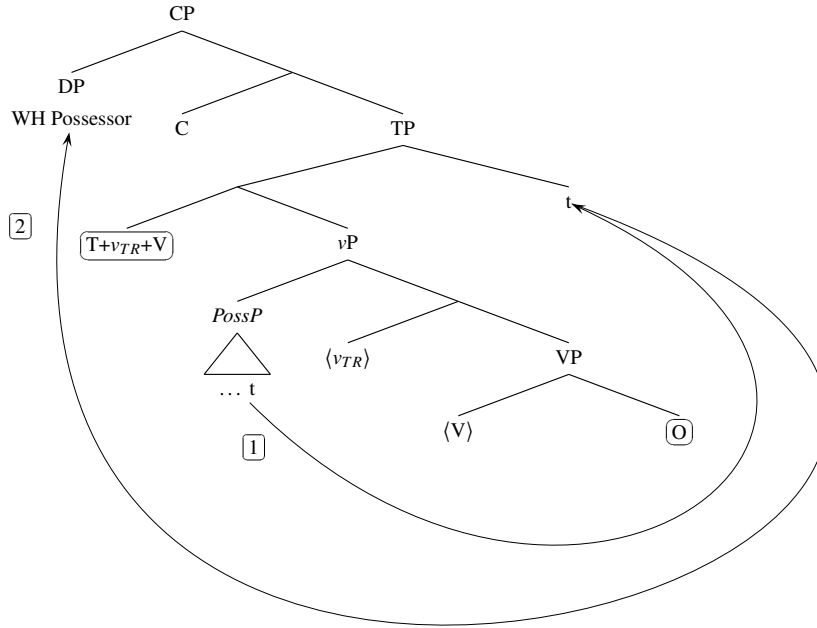
This step of A-movement is depicted in 1 in (7) (recall that, following Aissen and Polian 2025, T has a right-oriented specifier).⁶ Only once the possessor is in this external A-position can it be targeted for $\bar{A}$ -movement to spec-CP 2. Aissen and Polian 2025 propose that there is no direct $\bar{A}$ -subextraction out of nominals of any size, a selective opacity effect

⁵Unless cited otherwise, all Tseltalan data come from Aissen and Polian 2025. Aissen and Polian also claim that their analysis extends beyond Tseltalan to other Mayan languages, such as Ch’ol (in a reinterpretation of the findings of Little 2020).

⁶Aissen and Polian claim that the DP moved to spec-TP is interpreted as a Categorical Subject, in the sense of Kuroda 1972.

in the sense of Keine 2019. Putative $\bar{A}$ -subextraction of possessors in Tseltalan is therefore always mediated by A-movement.

(7)



Evidence that possessors can undergo A-movement to spec-TP comes from the independent availability of discontinuous possessors and possessa, (8). When a possessor is separated from its possessum, the possessum must be interpreted as non-specific. This suggests that movement to spec-TP targets DPs, but cannot target DPs embedded within DPs. If the possessive phrase is specific (i.e., a DP), then only the entire constituent can be targeted by the A-probe—the A-probe will move the first DP that it finds.

- (8) Ch'ay [PossP s-tak'in ____i] ajk'ube [DP te x-Mal=e]_i
 lost.INTR A3-money yesterday DET CLF-Maria=ENC
 'Maria lost some (non-spec.) money yesterday.'
 # 'Maria's money (spec.) was lost yesterday.' (Tenejapa Tseltal)

3.1.2 SMPM

Like Tseltalan, PPWI in SMPM triggers a specific interpretation of the fronted possessive, (9a), while non-specific possessives must remain *in situ*. But unlike in Tseltalan, leaving the possessum *in situ* in SMPM does not entail a non-specific interpretation. Stranded possessa can be interpreted as either non-specific or specific, (9b). These examples are repeated from (2).

- (9) a. [Yóó se'ě ___] kàku ___ ?
 who child be.born.COMPL
 'Whose child was born?'

- b. **Yóó nà** kàku [**se'ě** ___]?
 who 3PL born.COMPL child
 ‘Who (pl.) had a child born?’ / ‘Whose (pl.) child was born?’ (SMPM)

Additional evidence that stranded possessa can be interpreted specifically is shown in (10). The pre-nominal morpheme *míí*—a strong definite marker which encodes both uniqueness and familiarity (Ostrove 2024)—can occur with a stranded possessum.

- (10) **Yóó nà** íyo [**míí** vè'ě ntsi'i ___] Ahuejutla?
 who 3PL exist.CONT FAM house blue A.
 ‘Whose is the blue house in Ahuejutla?’

A second difference with Tseltalan is the size of non-specific nominals. We are unaware of any structural or positional differences between non-specific and specific possessives in SMPM. Indeed, the same surface string (with an overt numeral) is ambiguous between a specific and non-specific reading. Note also that, given our analysis of SMPM word order, (4), this means that non-specific nominal objects may undergo object shift.

- (11) *Context 1:* My grandfather died before I was born and I want to know what he looked like.
Context 2: A few years ago my mother showed me a nice photo of my grandfather when he was young. I would like to see it again.
 Nantik=í **iin fóto táta latn=ì.**
 look.CONT=1SG one foto father grand=1SG
 ‘I am looking for a photo of my grandfather.’

We take this to mean that nominal arguments in SMPM are DPs, regardless of interpretation—there are no structurally reduced non-specific possessive phrases as in Tseltalan.

A third difference between Tseltalan and SMPM is that SMPM does not allow discontinuous possessa and non-wh possessors, unlike Tseltalan (cf. (8))—there are no external possessors in SMPM.⁷

- (12) Kàku (*Pedro) [iin se'ě (✓**Pedro**)] nuù ntova (*Pedro)
 born.COMPL P. one child P. town Oaxaca P.
 ‘Pedro had a child born in Oaxaca City.’

⁷The only way to separate a non-wh possessor from the possessum is via focalization to a preverbal position (Hedding 2022)—i.e., $\bar{A}$ -movement.

- (i) PEDRO kàku [iin se'ě ___] nuù ntova
 P. born.COMPL one child town Oaxaca
 ‘PEDRO had a child born in Oaxaca City.’

We interpret these three empirical differences to mean that, unlike in Tseltalan, possessors in SMPM may be directly $\bar{A}$ -extracted out of DPs without an initial A-movement step to spec-TP out of a structurally reduced possessive phrase.

3.2 Movement possibilities in transitive clauses

We now expand our empirical scope to explore movement possibilities out of transitive clauses. This reveals another difference: (apparent) subextraction is not possible out of external arguments in SMPM, but is possible in Tseltalan. This difference will inform our analysis in §4.

3.2.1 Tseltalan

In Tseltalan, putative “subextraction” out of a transitive object is generally disallowed. This restriction follows from Aissen and Polian’s (2025) analysis: possessors within transitive objects do not undergo A-movement to spec-TP, and without an initial A-movement step they cannot undergo $\bar{A}$ -movement.

- (13) ***Much’u** avi-il [s-tseb ____] ta ch’ivit?
who A2-see A3-girl P market
Intended: ‘Whose daughter did you see in the market?’ (Tsotsil)

However, overt applicative morphology adds another potential A-position (besides spec-TP) that possessors within transitive objects can move to. Thus, possessors can “subextract” out of transitive objects if and only if there is overt applicative morphology, as this step of A-movement to spec-AppIP can feed subsequent $\bar{A}$ -movement.⁸

- (14) Mach’a_i la a-man-*(bey) tal [_{POSSP} s-lok’ombail t_i] t_i?
who COMPL A2-buy-APPL DIR A3-representation
‘Who did you buy a picture of?’ (Tenango Tseltal)

Previous work has also noticed that subextraction out of transitive subjects is generally disallowed in Mayan languages (e.g. Aissen 1996, Coon 2009, Little 2020).

- (15) ***Much’u** i-y-elk’an chij [x-ch’amal ____]?
who COMPL-A3-steal sheep A3-child.of.male
Intended: ‘Whose child stole sheep?’ (Tsotsil)

However, Aissen and Polian conclude that this restriction is reducible to the prohibition of A-movement out of a specific DP. Transitive subjects “overwhelmingly reference specific

⁸Moreover, if there is an overt applied argument (blocking spec-AppIP as an A-position), then “subextraction” once again is impossible (Aissen and Polian 2025:18). Little (2020) makes the same observation for another Mayan language, Ch’ol.

individuals” in Mayan languages (see various citations in Aissen and Polian 2025, 45), but in the rare cases that they are non-specific (PossPs), “subextraction” out of them is allowed.

- (16) **Macha’a** la s-wilunta-on [x-ch’akul ___]?
 who COMPL A3-fly.onto-B1 A3-flea
 ‘Whose fleas landed on me?’ (Tenejapa Tseltal)

Thus, these restrictions on apparent subextraction in Tseltalan are not due to the position of the argument, but rather to (i) whether the possessive phrase is structurally reduced (allowing A-movement out of it) and (ii) whether there is an A-position to which the possessor may move. This means that “subextraction” out of a transitive object is impossible without an applicative, and “subextraction” out of a transitive subject is only possible in the (rare) case that it is non-specific.

3.2.2 SMPM

In contrast to Tseltalan, in Hedding and Yuan to appear we show that subextraction out of direct objects is readily available in SMPM, (17).

- (17) **Yóó** xìx=ún [ntsiàjyí và’a ñà’ă ___]?
 who eat.COMPL=2SG broth good POSS
 ‘Whose mole did you eat?’

This is true, even if the object is specific, by virtue of the context, (18).⁹

- (18) *Context:* I enter a house and see a woman cooking goat meat. I saw her goat still alive as I entered the house, so I know it is not her goat that she is cooking.
Yóó xà’ń ntó [tyú’u sàná ___]?
 who kill.COMPL 2PL goat POSS.AML
 ‘Whose goat did you all kill?’

Note that, unlike in Tseltalan, there is no special applicative morphology necessary to subextract out of a transitive object. In fact, we are not aware of any dedicated A-position for applied arguments in SMPM. Indirect arguments are not introduced with applicative verbal morphology, but are rather enclosed in complex DPs containing body-part relational nouns.¹⁰

- (19) Nì-tsìvi karro ñà’ă Maria (**nùjǔ ñá**)
 COMPL-break.down car POSS M. face 3SG.F
 ‘Maria’s car broke down (on her).’

⁹These examples are thus parallel to the examples shown throughout §3.1.2, which show that specific unaccusative subjects (also internal arguments) may be subextracted from as well.

¹⁰We leave open the question of whether these XPs are synchronically DPs or PPs.

Transitive subjects, on the other hand, do not permit subextraction in SMPM at all, as first discussed in Hedding 2020 and Hedding and Yuan to appear.

- (20) *Yóó xàxi [tsìnà sàrà ____] kôñù?
 who eat.COMPL dog POSS.AML meat
 Intended: ‘Whose dog ate the meat?’

Importantly, we show below that this effect cannot be explained in terms of specificity (as it can be in Tseltalan). This is because subextraction out of transitive subjects is categorically blocked in SMPM, even when the possessum is interpreted as non-specific as in (21).

- (21) *Context:* Some people in town want to pick up some heavy machinery and they need a large truck. However, they are not sure if anyone in town has a truck that is big enough. They ask:
 *Yóó và’a kuísó [karro ña’ă ____] *maquina* vejě
 who good carry.POT car POSS machine heavy
 Intended: ‘Who has a truck that can carry heavy machinery?’

Moreover, as we demonstrated above, there is no general ban on the subextraction out of specific DP objects in SMPM. Consequently, even if all subjects were interpreted specifically, we could not appeal to this as an explanation for the ban on moving out of transitive subjects. Thus, the restriction in SMPM resembles a true subject-object (or external argument-internal argument) asymmetry, rather than a restriction based on specificity, as in Tseltalan.

3.3 Interim Summary

Despite the superficially similar patterns in Tseltalan and SMPM, we find 6 key distinctions between them, repeated below.

	Tseltalan	SMPM	
Stranded possessum must be non-specific	YES	NO	§3.1
Non-specifics structurally smaller	YES	NO	§3.1
External Possession possible	YES	NO	§3.1
Transitive objects opaque	YES	NO	§3.2
Transitive objects opaque without ApplP	YES	NO	§2.3
Transitive subjects transparent if non-specific	YES	NO	§3.2

Recall the basic components of Aissen and Polian’s (2025) analysis: (i) possessor DPs cannot directly $\bar{A}$ -move out of any possessive constituent, but can A-move out of it (selective opacity); (ii) A-movement feeds subsequent $\bar{A}$ -movement to spec-CP; (iii) only reduced PossPs (non-specific nominals), not DPs (specific nominals), allow possessor A-movement out of them. None of these components are motivated for SMPM given the

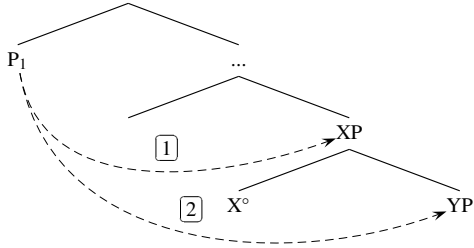
differences outlined above. Consequently, we propose that in SMPM, possessors directly $\bar{A}$ -extract out of DPs, and do so without an intermediate A-movement step.

4. Obviating DP phases (in SMPM)

The conclusions above raise three interrelated questions: (i) how is genuine possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction out of DPs achieved in SMPM, (ii) why is it blocked out of transitive subject DPs, and (iii) why is the derivation we propose for SMPM not available in the Tseltalan languages at all? Our proposal ties the relevant contrast to the phasal status of complex DPs: SMPM has a mechanism for obviating DP phases, but Tseltalan does not.

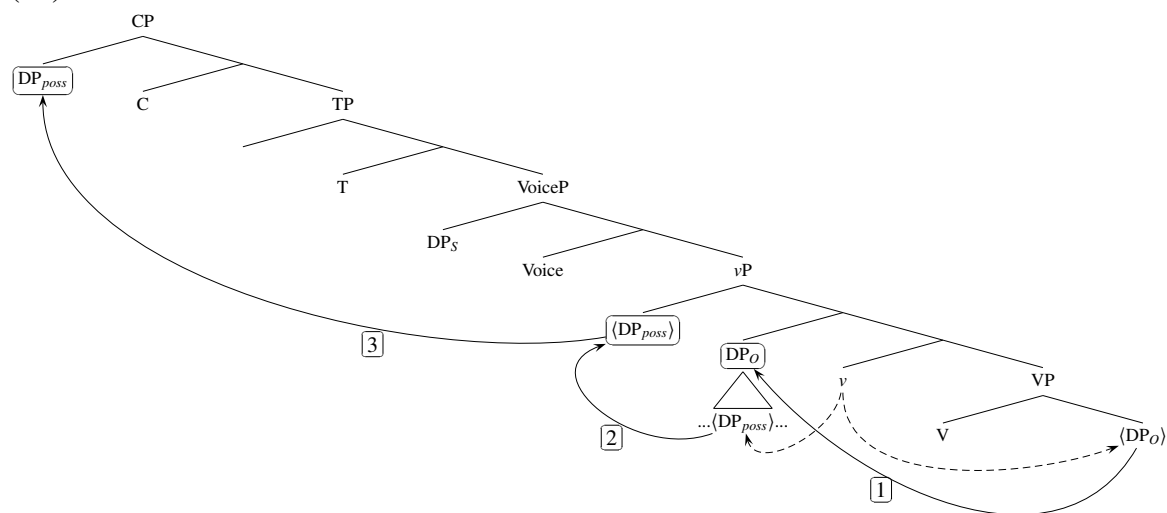
The motivation for this analytical direction comes from the aforementioned observation that SMPM permits $\bar{A}$ -extraction out of unaccusative subjects and transitive objects, but not out of transitive subjects. In Hedding and Yuan to appear, we connected this asymmetry to the ‘unlocking’ theory of phases (e.g. Rackowski and Richards 2005, van Urk and Richards 2015, Halpert 2019, Ershova 2024, Lee and Yip 2024): as shown in (22), a constituent may be subextracted out of a phase, [2], only if the movement-triggering head has first Agreed with the phase itself, [1]. This view recasts phase impenetrability in terms of a Relativized Minimality effect, which may be overridden through multiple Agree with and into the phase (see Halpert and Zeijlstra 2024 for discussion of this latter point).

(22)



The aforementioned $\bar{A}$ -extraction asymmetry in SMPM therefore results from two general properties of the language. As shown in (4) above, phasal v c-commands internal arguments but not external arguments, which are generated higher in spec-VoiceP. Moreover, recall that internal arguments undergo object shift to spec- v P in the derivation of basic V(P)-S-O word order. We argue that Agree between phasal v and an internal argument DP not only drives object shift, but also ‘unlocks’ that DP for subsequent possessor $\bar{A}$ -subextraction. These steps are shown throughout (23). Note that, although steps [2]-[3] in (23) depict the possessor DP first raising to an outer specifier of v before raising to spec-CP (following van Urk and Richards 2015), this is not crucial to the analysis.

(23)



Importantly, the inability to subextract out of transitive subject DPs in SMPM results from the fact that these DPs are not Agreed with by phasal *v*; as such, they remain opaque.¹¹

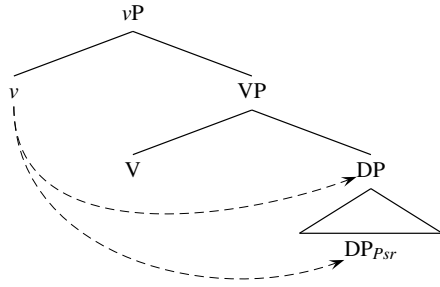
In contrast to SMPM, recall that all DPs in Tseltalan remain opaque for subextraction. But what prevents unlocking of object DPs in Tseltalan? Indeed, recall from §2 that *v* *does* Agree with the object in Tseltalan, since it is responsible for ABS case assignment (=set B verbal agreement), (24).

- (24) La j-pas-b-**at** ul
COMPL A1-make-APPL-B2SG atole
'I made atole for you.'
(Oxchuc Tseltal; Polian 2013)

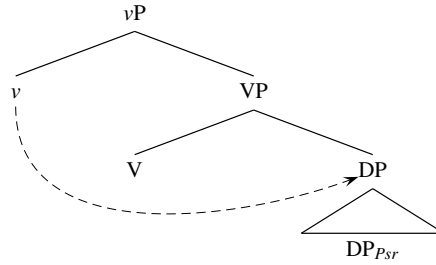
We propose that the (in)ability to unlock a DP phase in SMPM and Tseltalan is reducible to variation in the *probing conditions of phasal* v . Per our analysis above, v in SMPM may undergo multiple Agree, permitting it to unlock an outer DP phase *and* $\bar{A}$ -extract the inner DP possessor, (25a). We now suggest that Tseltalan v probes just only once, resulting in ABS) case assignment to the DP. As a result, v is unable to subextract anything inside of that DP, (25b).

¹¹In Hedding and Yuan to appear, we also show that unergative subjects are opaque to subextraction, but we have not yet systematically tested this with both specific and non-specific possessa.

(25) a. Multiple Agree (in SMPM)



b. Single Agree (in Tseltalan)



There are various possible ways of implementing this distinction. Under an interaction/satisfaction theory of Agree (Deal 2015), for instance, v could be characterized as *insatiable* in SMPM (thus able to Agree with multiple goals), whereas in Tseltalan it is satisfied after a single round of Agree. See also Halpert 2019 for discussion of this particular model of Agree in an unlocking theory of phases. Note also that, if v can only Agree once in Tseltalan (to assign ABS), then we require a different source for ERG case assignment (set A agreement). We assume this is Voice, not v —plausible if the transitive subject is introduced in spec-VoiceP (as depicted in (3)) and ERG case in Mayan languages is inherent (e.g. Coon 2017).

Regardless of the exact model of Agree assumed, there is independent evidence for this multiple vs. single Agree distinction from ditransitives in SMPM and Tseltalan. In SMPM ditransitives, all internal argument DPs undergo object shift out of the VP, so it is already revealed from more general considerations of SMPM word order that v may Agree with multiple possible goals. As shown in (26), neither the direct nor the indirect object may raise with the fronted VP, meaning that they must have both raised to distinct specifiers of v prior to VP remnant movement. Our extension here is simply that v may also Agree *into* DPs for $\bar{A}$ -subextraction purposes. In contrast, the Mayan languages are considered *primary object languages* (e.g. Dryer 1986), meaning that v Agrees with just one internal argument. In a ditransitive construction in Tseltalan, (27), only the indirect object is indexed by agreement; there is no Agree dependency established between v and the direct object. Therefore, if phasal v in Tseltalan ceases probing as soon as it encounters a DP, it cannot ever access a DP-internal wh-possessor.

- (26) [_{VP} Tàxin $t_i t_j$]_k Maria [iin ntsikǎ]_i [ndà'ǎ Juan]_j t_k
 give.COMPL Maria one banana hand Juan
 ‘Maria gave a banana to Juan.’

- (27) L-i-y-ak'-be *pro* tak'in li Xune
 COMPL-B1-A3-give-APPL money DET Xun
 ‘Xun gave me the money.’

(Tsotsil; Aissen 1983)

In sum, in addition to the differences highlighted throughout §3, another crucial divergence found in these languages concerns the probing behavior of v . Coupled with the ‘unlocking’

theory of phases, we have proposed that whether a DP can be rendered transparent for $\bar{A}$ -subextraction is determined by whether v may probe more than once to begin with.

5. Summary and conclusion

We have shown that, despite having surface similarities, possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction in Tseltalan and SMPM involve *distinct syntactic derivations*. Specifically, these distinct profiles result from several interrelated parametric differences between the two languages, including the functional heads implicated in the derivation of verb-initiality and the loci of A-positions for DPs (§2), nominal size and its correlation to specificity (§3), and the probing conditions of phasal v (§4).

Finally, although we have identified and sought to account for differences between just Tseltalan and SMPM, recall that the Mesoamerican linguistic area spans multiple language families and isolate languages. Our analysis makes testable predictions about the $\bar{A}$ -subextraction patterns of other Mesoamerican languages not discussed here—specifically, how possessor $\bar{A}$ -extraction might map to the array of grammatical properties outlined above.

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